

Rolling Thunder

From 1965 to 1968, an air campaign against North Vietnam ran in tandem with the fighting in the South. After a number of earlier “retaliatory strikes” against the North, a sustained air offensive, codenamed Rolling Thunder, was set in motion in March 1965. Although often described as a strategic bombing campaign, Rolling Thunder was really nothing of the kind. Wary of escalating the war or alienating world opinion, the US government placed a series of limits on the use of air power that precluded in advance any possibility of achieving the prime goal of strategic bombing – that is, the destruction of the enemy’s industrial and military infrastructure. Whole areas of North Vietnam were declared “sanctuaries,” out of bounds for bombing, including the chief cities, Hanoi and Haiphong, and a broad zone near the Chinese border. And even within areas where bombing was permitted, specific targets were often ruled out – for example, port facilities and, initially, air-defense systems.

The campaign was executed not by America’s strategic bombers but by tactical strike aircraft – F-100s, F-4s, F-105s – focusing initially on targets such as bridges, roads, and supply dumps. This was in essence an interdiction campaign, attempting to impede the flow of men and supplies from the North into South Vietnam. Yet the US government persisted in hoping that it might achieve a strategic objective by inflicting enough damage to persuade the North Vietnamese to stop supporting the war in the South. The rules governing the campaign were

ANTIAIRCRAFT DEFENSES

North Vietnamese SAMs and anti-aircraft guns combined to erect a formidable barrier against American air raids. The anti-aircraft guns were deadly at low altitude, forcing the American planes to fly higher, where the SAMs were most effective.



STRIKE PACKAGE



FOR RAIDS ON NORTH VIETNAM, the US air forces assembled “strike packages” in which support aircraft greatly outnumbered those tasked with hitting the target. Furthest from the action were KC-135 tankers, which refueled the combat aircraft. An RC-121 radar-surveillance aircraft acted as an aerial command post, giving early warning of MiGs taking off. EB-66B Destroyers, packed with electronic countermeasures equipment, flew high above the strike force, escorted by F-4s. The EB-66Bs were intended to jam ground radars, “blinding” the SAMs and anti-aircraft guns. In case they failed, Wild Weasel F-105s or F-4s armed with antiradiation missiles went ahead to shoot it out with the SAMs. At the heart of the package were 20 or 30 F-105 strike aircraft armed with bombs and Bullpup missiles, surrounded by F-4s to fight off any MiGs. A single mission could easily involve 100 aircraft.

THUD STRIKE

The Republic F-105 Thunderchief, known to pilots as the “Thud,” was America’s prime ground-attack aircraft in Vietnam. Fast, robust, and packed with complex electronic equipment, it was designed to penetrate the most sophisticated air defenses carrying an impressive payload of missiles and bombs.

GUIDED BULLPUP

The Bullpup was America’s standard air-to-ground guided missile in the early years of the Vietnam War. It was radio-guided on to its target by a controller in the launch aircraft using a small joystick. The Bullpup was superseded by fire-and-forget missiles that “locked on” to their targets.



periodically changed to build up pressure – a new type of target allowed or the area in which bombing was permitted extended. On occasion a “bombing pause” was declared, to give the communists time for reflection. None of this worked at all because it was based on the false idea that a bombed government and people would respond according to rational cost analysis, rather than with the gut emotion of defiance.

So Rolling Thunder was a strange concoction

in which essentially tactical bombing was used for allegedly strategic purposes – bombing bridges to undermine a country’s will to resist. The tight rules of engagement, which put pilots’ lives at risk and blunted the effectiveness of air operations, were partly designed to limit the numbers of civilian casualties caused. And yet this did not prevent the United States from being criticized worldwide for carrying out the bombing campaign, which is estimated to have killed around 50,000 North Vietnamese. Even US